

Testament writings which has been so inadequately studied, and which is so seriously misunderstood among Old Testament scholars at present. St. Jerome put the tremendous weight of his authority against it (in his Preface to Ezra and Nehemiah: *Nec quemquam moveat quod unus a nobis liber editus est, nec apocryphorum tertii et quarti somniis delectetur; quia et apud Hebraeos Esdrae Nehemiaeque sermones in unum volumen coarctantur, et quae non habentur apud illos, nec de viginti quatuor senibus sunt, procul abjicienda*), and his word was law, as usual, for the Latin church from the Middle Ages onward, and exercised a profound influence over the whole western world. The book was excluded from the Complutensian Polyglot (1514-17), and was not even admitted by the Council of Trent (1546);¹ in printed editions of the Vulgate it is given place in an appendix at the end of the Bible, after the New Testament. By modern scholars generally this "apocryphal book" is not regarded as a survival from the old Greek version of this portion of the Old Testament, nor even as the part of a recension which once included all of Ezra and Nehemiah; on the contrary, it is believed to be a later free compilation made with a "tendency." That is, just as the Chronicler, in his day, edited and expanded certain parts of the history of Israel into a book which should inculcate his own views, so (according to the generally accepted theory) a later and unknown writer selected that part of the history which "began" with Josiah's passover (as though this were a natural beginning!) and ended with the career of Ezra, and rewrote it, with certain significant changes and additions, according to his own purpose.

This view is altogether mistaken, but it is the only one which has any recognition at the present time. All of the modern textbooks of Introduction, commentaries, and encyclopaedia articles, whether English, German, or French, speak of the "author" of First Esdras, and of his probable "purpose" in making this com-

¹ It is singular that the belief should have had such wide currency, at this time, that First Esdras *did not exist in Greek*. Thus Lupton, in his Introduction to First Esdras (*Speaker's Commentary*), p. 5, quotes the remark prefixed to the Latin version of the book in the noted Latin Bible edited and published by Stephanus at Paris in 1557: "*Hujus libri ne Graecum quidem codicem, nedum Hebraeum nemini (quod sciam) videre contigit.*" The form of the quotation which I give is that of the original, of which I have a copy. Lupton is mistaken, however, in supposing that this note is to be attributed to the scholar Vatablus (whose name is used in an unwarranted way by the editor of this Bible); nor can it have come from Claudius Badwell, who did indeed prepare the translation of the Apocrypha for this Bible (see LeLong-Masch, *Bibl. Sacra*, II, p. 480), but only of the books which stood in the Complutensian Polyglot. The remark is to be attributed to Stephanus himself or to one of his unnamed helpers.